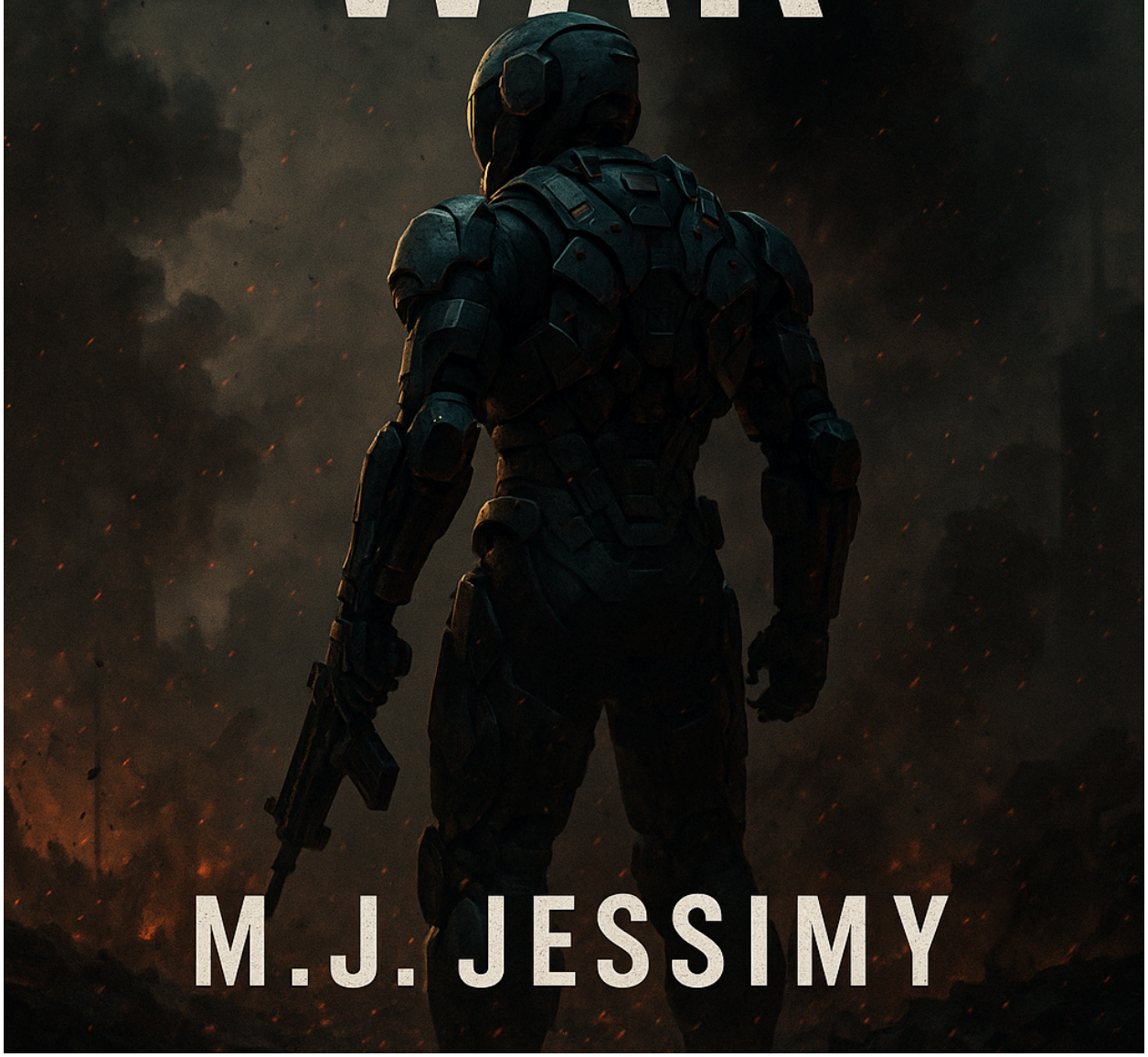
THE ONE PERCENT WAR



M.J. JESSIMY

The One Percent War

M.J Jessimy

Copyright

Copyright © 2025 by M.J. Jessimy
All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

Preface

In a war without end, the Federation has found its edge—a breakthrough military technology that turns soldiers into near-mythic warriors on the battlefield. Fast. Precise. Unstoppable. With victory finally within reach, hope spreads across the nation like wildfire.

But hope has a cost.

As momentum builds and cities fall back into Federation hands, something begins to shift. Whispers emerge. Units vanish. And behind the silence, a pattern starts to form—one the public isn't meant to see.

Told through the detached eye of history, *The One Percent War* explores the dark intersection of innovation and desperation in a world that no longer asks whether the price is too high… only whether it can be paid in time.

Prepare for a bleak descent into the machinery of modern warfare—where progress is measured in bodies, and victory is always one heartbeat away.

They called it the Equalizer.

The exosuit was sleek, silent, and surgically efficient. It turned twenty-year-old privates into war gods. Enemies fell before them like wheat beneath harvest blades. With each deployment, Federation lines surged forward, reclaiming scorched territories long abandoned to the Eastern Pact. Commanding officers watched live feeds with quiet awe, whispering things like *"unstoppable,"* and *"finally."*

No one asked what it cost. Not at first.

The Equalizer ran on a proprietary bio-circuitry system—adaptive, intelligent, alive in a way metal shouldn't be. It responded to thought and instinct. When a soldier gritted their teeth, the suit clenched with them. When adrenaline spiked, the servos pushed past known limits. And when a soldier bled, it tightened around them like a second skin, sealing the wound, bearing the weight, dragging them forward.

For every activation, one percent of a soldier's life was burned away. Quietly. Precisely.

No one told them. The cost was classified.

The war was old. It had dragged across borders, oceans, atmospheres. Cities were razed and rebuilt in the span of a single soldier's career. People didn't talk about victory anymore. They talked about *managing* the war. About *holding ground.* About *cost-efficiency.*

But then the Equalizer came.

Within six months, the Federation took back three strongholds. Armored troopers shattered tanks with punches. They leapt over craters, sprinted through gunfire, caught missiles mid-air and flung them back like toys. Propaganda clips looped endlessly on state feeds: boys with shining helmets walking calmly through fire. Girls in exosuits carrying entire platoons on their backs. Smiling, teeth white, skin shining with sweat and praise.

No one asked what happened to them afterward.

The first to die were written off as coincidence. Heart attacks. Aneurysms. Overexertion. But then came the mass graves.

Entire companies dropping dead within a week.

A soldier named Vaskas collapsed mid-field. Eyes open, mouth agape, suit still active. No visible injuries. Then another. Then four more. Medical Command issued an internal memo: “Potential viral exposure in front-line units. Initiate sterilization protocol.” The bodies were burned. No autopsies.

Then came the videos.

A whistleblower leaked footage to the blacknets. Helmet cams showing soldiers checking vitals of comrades who’d simply stopped breathing. A sergeant screaming, *“He was fine a minute ago!”* Another pacing in circles, muttering, *“We just got the suits last month. He was twenty-three.”*

By the time command acknowledged the deaths, three thousand were gone.

The truth leaked slower than the corpses piled up.

One percent.

That was the phrase whispered in mess halls. Spoken in half-sentences on encrypted chats. The Equalizer cost one percent of your lifespan every time it booted up. Every activation—combat mode, adrenaline spike, stress response—drained you. They didn't tell the soldiers because soldiers don't get to say no.

Some tried to game it. They stopped using the suit unless under fire. But it was too late. Once synced, the suit activated itself during perceived threats, automatic adrenaline syncs. Even nightmares triggered it. One soldier died in his sleep.

Recruitment plummeted. Volunteers dried up.

So conscription came back.

They called it the Silent Collapse.

The war map stopped updating. Federation spokespeople blamed “data latency.” But everyone knew. The Pact was advancing. Regained two border zones in a week. Federation front lines became empty holes where units used to be. Officers requisitioned suits and refused to wear them. Draftees sabotaged training facilities. Some fled. Others took their own lives before deployment.

Then the broadcasts changed.

No more victorious montages.

Only a single message, repeated every hour.

> **"Your country needs you. Enrollment now open for citizens aged 12 and up. Training adjusted for your capabilities. Protect your future. Serve the Federation."**

Twelve. Years. Old.

A boy named Ishan watched the message flicker across his family's holoscreen. His mother said nothing. His father stared into the table. Outside, the distant sound of a shuttle cut the silence—another collection transport, another neighborhood swept.

Ishan turned away and whispered, *"I don't want to be a god."*

His mother said, *"You don't have to be."*

But the door knocked five minutes later. Two officers. Polite. Efficient. They handed her a consent form and told her it was optional.

She signed with shaking hands. She didn't ask why her signature was already printed on the form. Did she have a real choice?

By the time analysts pieced it all together, the numbers were too vast to hide.

The average life lost per soldier: 47 years.

Some lasted longer. Some less. But the war didn’t care. The war devoured them in silence, burning down the future one life at a time.

Command knew. Had always known. It was in the schematics. In the fine print of neural sync protocols. The suits didn’t kill. The suits *borrowed.* And no one asked what happened when the debt came due.

The Federation didn’t win. They almost did.

And almost was enough to kill them.

On the final day of the Offensive Quarter, every Equalizer unit on the field shut down.

No warning. No signal. No explanation.

They stood motionless—gleaming statues on broken ground. Some with hands still outstretched. Some kneeling. Some mid-stride. Inside, the soldiers were already dead.

Pact units advanced unhindered. No one fired. No one ran.

There was no one left to fight.

A week later, a new notice appeared on the Federation's national broadcast system:

> ⚠️ **EMERGENCY DIRECTIVE 47-A** ⚠️
>
> Effective immediately, Federation Defense Force lowers minimum conscription age to 12.
>
> All eligible citizens must report to nearest processing center within 72 hours. Equalizer suits re-calibrated for adolescent synchronization. Sacrifice is a privilege. The Federation thanks you.

There were no protest marches. No angry mobs.

Just silence. And lines of parents holding their children's hands as they waited in the cold, gray morning.

The children were quiet. Braver than they should be.

None of them asked how long they'd live.

They already knew.